Forced Removal of a Domain Controller from Active Directory

Let's assume the following scenario. We have a Domain Controller on the network that has ceased to work altogether, for some reason that we don't care about at this point. We have no backup, it will not work again, so we will need to completely remove it from the infrastructure.

To achieve this, we will need to implement a forced removal of the Domain Controller from Active Directory. Furthermore, because such an action leaves some orphaned metadata in the AD, we will then need to go ahead and clean up these metadata. In case the DC is somewhat online, the first action, however, is to try to demote it from AD.

With this scenario, we will deal with this article. Let's move on.

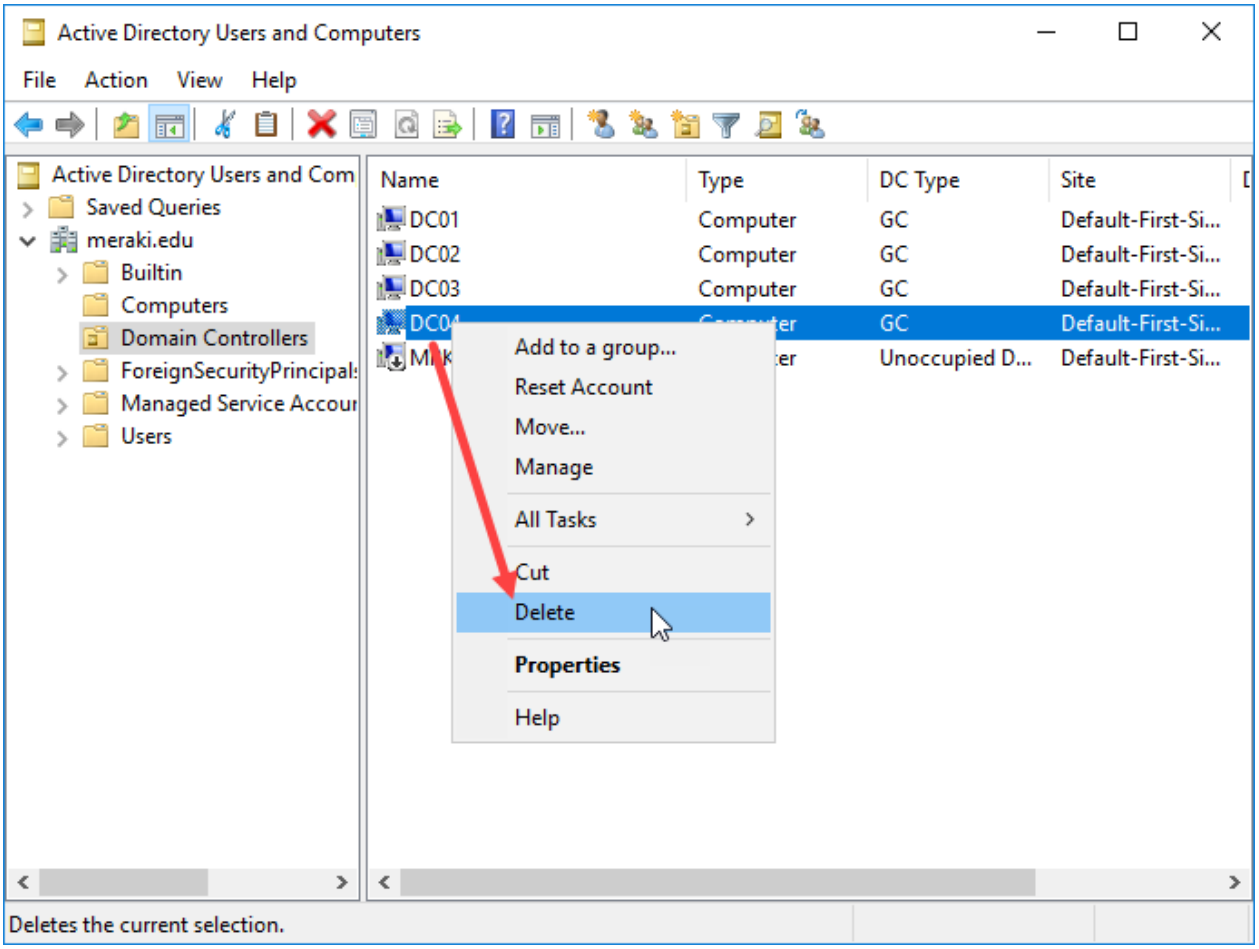
Forced removal of a Domain Controller from Active Directory

The forced removal of a DC can be done in 3 ways. Using the Active Directory Users and Computers console, Active Directory Sites and Services console, and the NTDSUtil command-line tool.

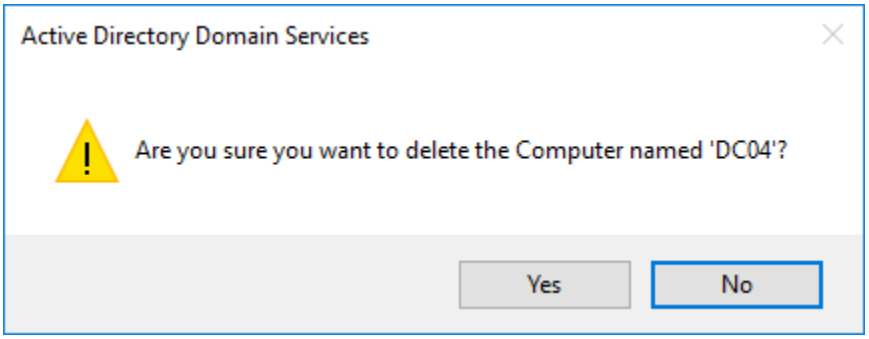
When you use the two consoles, Microsoft claims that the orphaned metadata are automatically cleaned. However, as you will see, there are still some records of the deleted DC, especially on the DNS console and Sites and Services. Although DNS scavenging takes care of removing them, personally when I delete a DC, I do a quick check of all DNS objects to confirm and delete all the records that are left.

Using the Users and Computers console

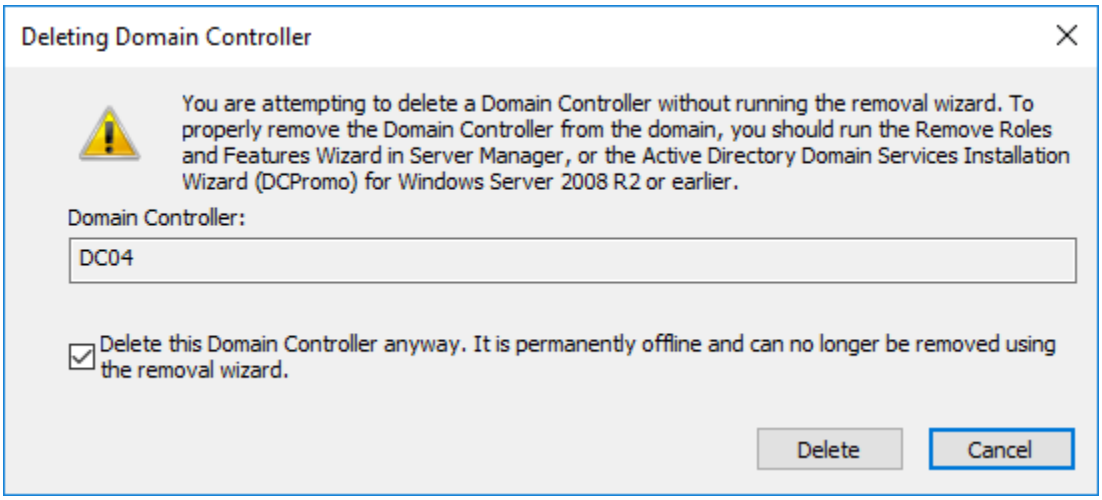
Open the **Active Directory Users and Computers** console and go to the **Domain Controllers** OU. Here, right-click the DC to be removed and then **Delete**.



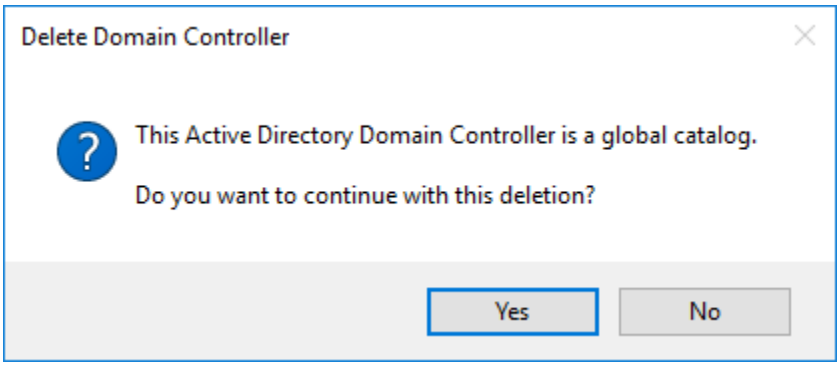
Confirm the deletion by pressing **Yes**.



Immediately afterward, you will see a message informing you that you are about to remove a Domain Controller without using the classic method we have described in an earlier article. If DC is not going to go back online again, you need to select the **Delete this Domain Controller anyway. It is permanently offline and can no longer be removed using the removal wizard** option, and then click the **Delete** button.



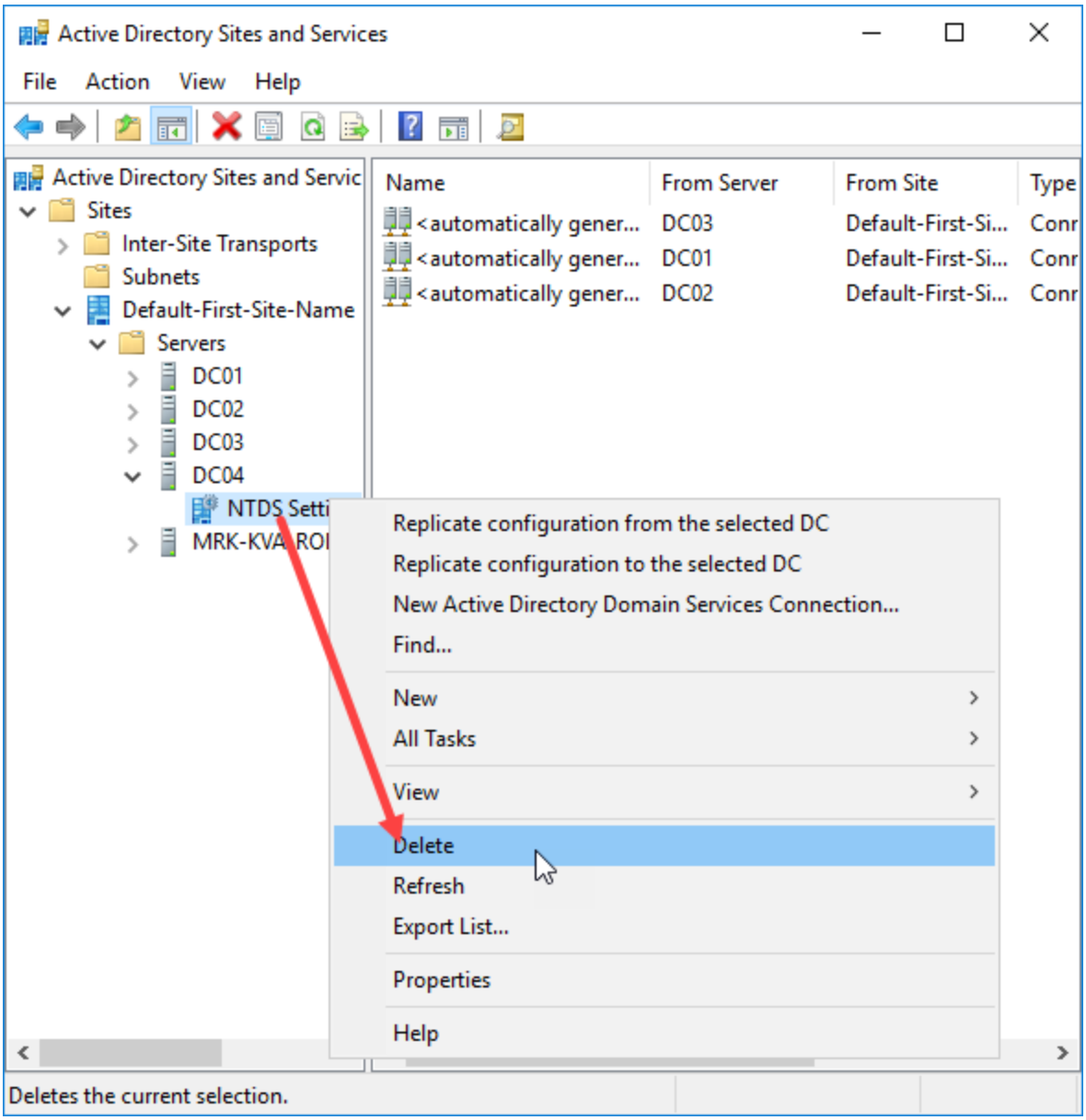
If the DC you are deleting was also a Global Catalog (GC) server, click **Yes** to confirm the deletion.



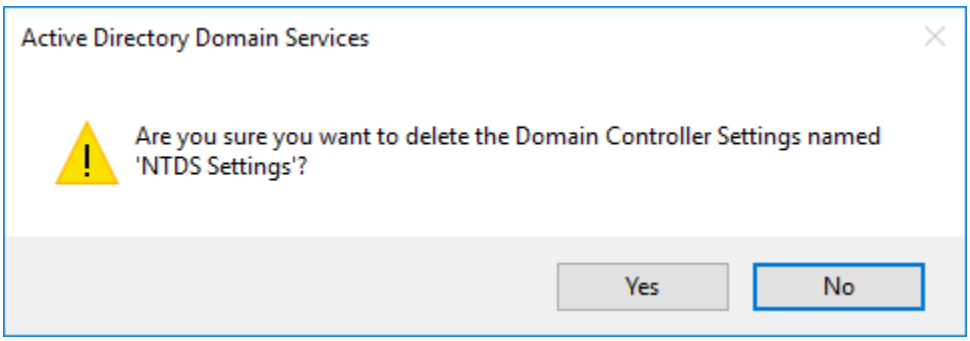
If the DC you are deleting had one or more FSMO roles, click **OK** to transfer them to another DC. This if you have not already seized them yourself.

Using Active Directory Sites and Services console

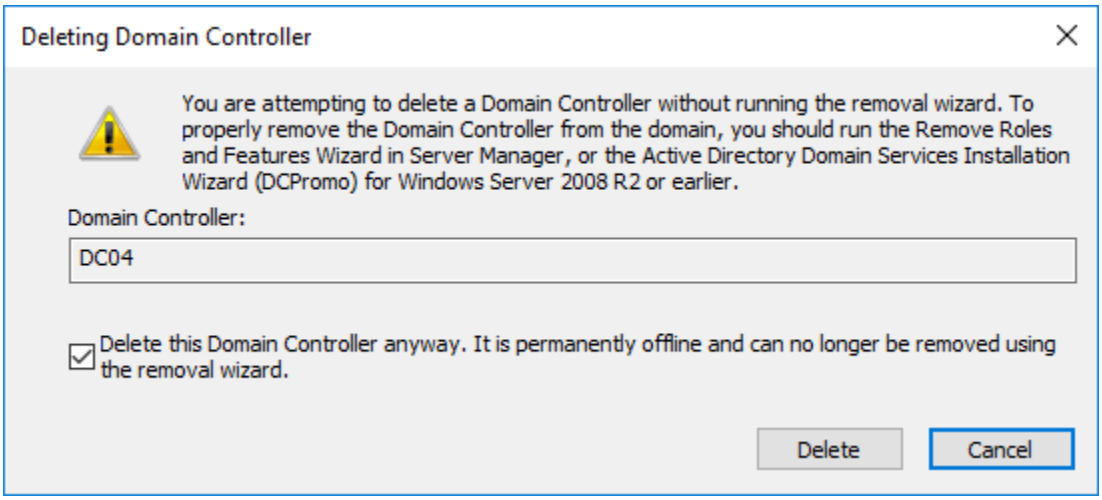
Open the **Active Directory Sites and Services** console, expand the **Sites** object till you find the DC you want to delete. Here, right-click the NTDS Settings icon on the DC, and then click **Delete**.



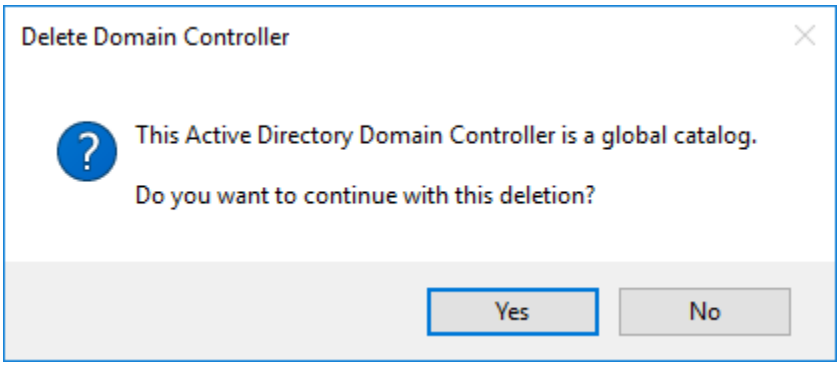
Confirm the deletion by pressing **Yes**.



Confirm again while accepting the warnings by clicking the **Delete** button.



As before, if DC was also Global Catalog and/or had at least one of the FSMO roles, you will need to confirm the deletion.



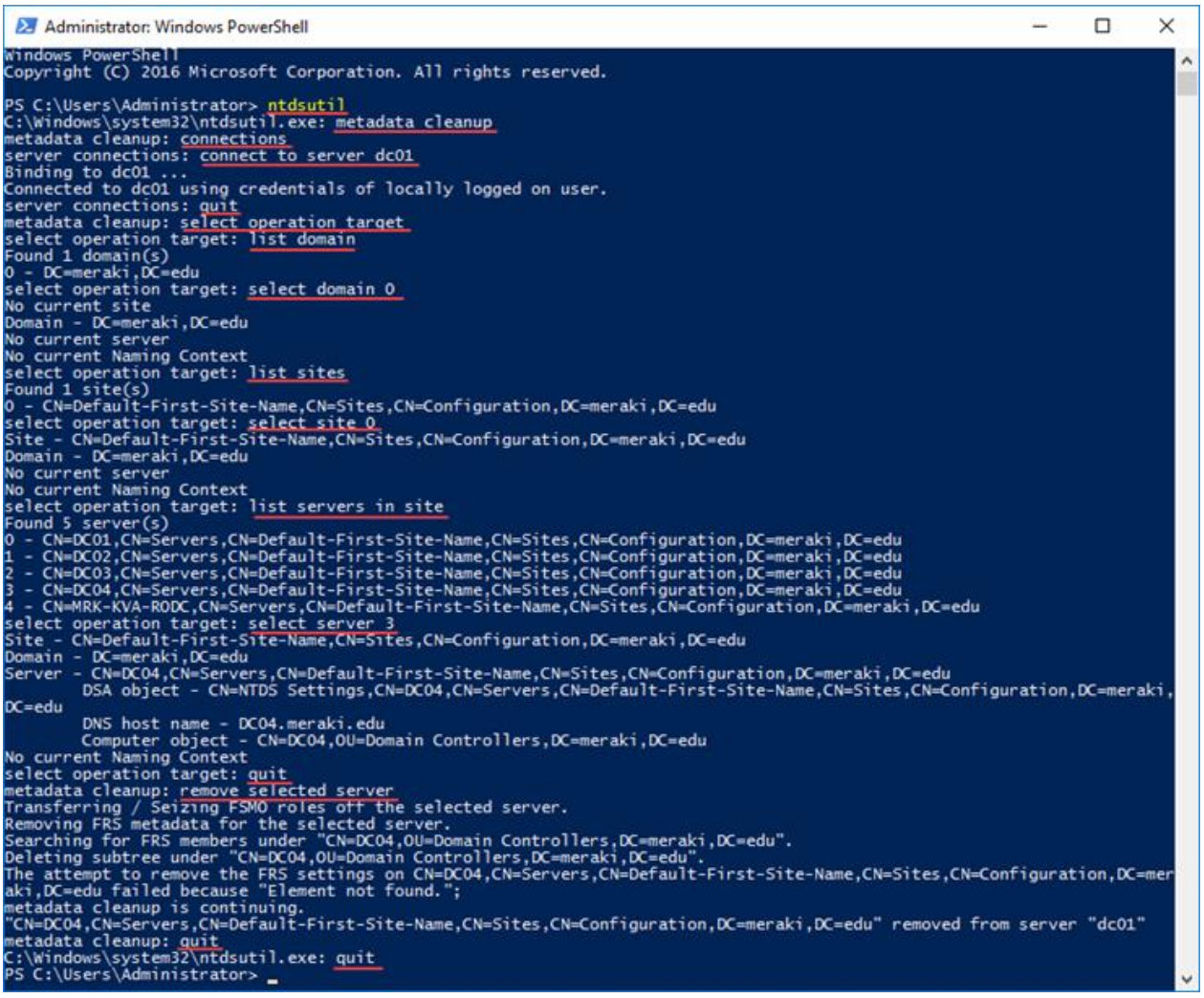
You can then delete the DC object in the Active Directory Sites and Services console.

Using the NTDSUtil tool

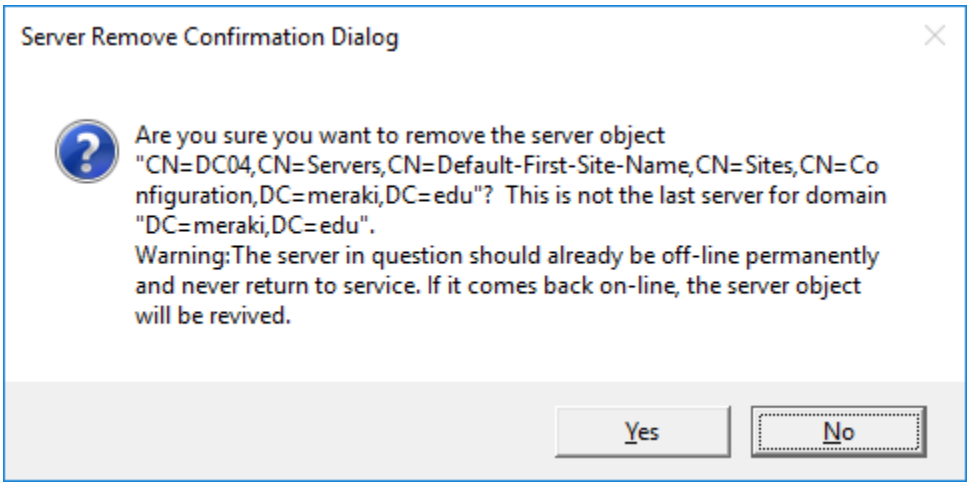
First, open the command line or PowerShell with administrator privileges.

Type **ntdsutil** and press **Enter**.
Type **metadata cleanup** and press **Enter**.
Type **connections** and press **Enter**.
Type **connect to server <-servername>** and press **Enter**. Where <-servername>, is the name of a working DC in the same domain.
Type **quit** and press **Enter**.
Type **select operation target** and press **Enter**.
Type **list domains** and press **Enter**.
Type **select domain <-number>** and press **Enter**. Where <-number>, the corresponding number to the domain that the non-functional DC member was a member of.
Type **list sites** and press **Enter**.
Type **select site <-number>** and press **Enter**. Where <-number>, the number that corresponds to

the site that the non-functional DC member was a member of.
Type **list servers in site** and press **Enter**.
Type **select server <-number>** and press **Enter**. Where <-number>, the number that corresponds to the DC you want to remove.
Type **quit** and press **Enter**.
Type **remove selected server** and press **Enter**.



In the confirmation window that appears, click **Yes** to continue the deletion process.



Finally, type **quit** and press **Enter** to exit the NTDSUtil management environment.

After completing the steps above as you like, do not forget to check all DNS objects to delete any records of the removed DC.

References:

https://www.dtonias.com/forced-removal-domain-controller/

http://www.briandesmond.com/blog/remove-an-offline-domain-controller